



P19 · 24 PAGES, FOR THE OLDER SIBLING AND THE FAMILY

A Sibling Adjustment Pack

Twenty-four pages for the family adding a second. Big-sibling welcome scripts, the regression expectations page, a "what to do during feeds" list, a first-week-with-two playbook, grandparent scripts so the older one is not eclipsed at the doorway, and a small page just for the older one.

Soothemade **Notes**

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

Adding another baby is not “double” what you already do. It is its own new event, and the experienced parent is also a new parent, because there has never been a version of this family before.

The advice you’ll find online tends to focus on the newborn (which is well-trodden ground) or on the marriage (which is fair). The older sibling tends to be addressed in two sentences: “they may regress” and “give them special attention.” Both true. Neither sufficient.

This pack is for the in-between weeks. The third trimester. The hospital stay. The first six weeks home. The first three months. With the older one held in mind throughout, because they are the person in your house whose entire universe is about to expand without their consent.

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A small framing, before anything else

A toddler or preschooler does not have the cognitive language to grieve. Their grief, when it shows up, will look like:

- Wanting to be carried everywhere again
- Asking to be fed by you, even though they can feed themselves
- Talking like a baby (baby talk, not their usual voice)
- Wanting to wear a diaper, even though they've been potty-trained for a year
- Suddenly being scared of the dark, of being alone, of the bathroom
- Hitting you, hitting the baby, hitting nothing
- Becoming clingy in a way that feels suffocating
- Becoming distant in a way that feels worse

None of these are "behaviors to fix." They are the only language the body has for "the family has changed and I am not sure if there is still a place for me here."

The work of this pack is to help you respond with "there is, and here it is" instead of "stop that."

Telling the older one

A week-by-week guide for the third trimester, depending on when you tell.

If you tell in week 8-12

Pros: the older child has time to absorb. Cons: the time between telling and the baby arriving is very long for a small person. They will likely forget, then re-remember, then forget. Each re-remembering is small grief.

If you tell in week 16-20 (around the anatomy scan)

The middle path. The child has time to ask questions, see your body change, but the wait isn't excruciating.

If you tell in week 28-30

Late but not too late. The body is now obvious. The child has the wait for ten weeks.

What to say (script)

You: "I want to tell you something exciting and big.
Our family is going to grow. There is going to
be a new baby coming."

Pause. Wait. Their face will do many things.

You: "The baby is in my body right now. It will take
a long time. They will arrive when [season /
month / 'when the leaves fall']."

Pause. Wait.

You: "You will still be our [kid / first kid / firstborn].
You will be our big sibling. We are very lucky
to have you. The new baby is lucky to have you too."

Pause. Wait.

You: "Do you have any questions?"

If they have no reaction, that's fine. If they have a big reaction, also fine. If they ask "but what about me?" you say what you wrote above again, slowly. They will need to hear it many times.

What NOT to say

- "The baby is going to be your best friend." (Not true for several years, and sets up a difficult moment in week three when the baby is screaming.)
- "You're going to love them." (You hope so. Setting an expectation creates pressure.)
- "Now you'll have someone to play with." (The newborn does not play. The 2-month-old does not play. This is a long arc.)
- "You're going to be a big helper." (Some children take to this. Others find it a heavy assignment. Wait and see what kind they are.)

- "We're so excited!" (You can be. But your excitement is not their assignment.)

What to do as the body changes

- Let them touch your belly when they want. Don't force.
- Talk to the baby out loud with them. ("The baby is moving. Want to feel?")
- Bring them to one or two appointments if you want. Not all.
- Buy them a doll if they're interested. Practice "feeding" and "carrying."
- Read books about siblings. There are many. Skip the ones with shiny instagram families.

The hospital day plan

A page to fill in. Print it before week 36.

WHO WATCHES THE OLDER ONE DURING LABOR AND DELIVERY

Primary plan: _____

At what house: _____

Pickup time: _____

Drop-off time: _____

Backup plan: _____

WHAT THE OLDER ONE BRINGS WITH THEM

- ☐ Their pajamas
- ☐ Their toothbrush
- ☐ A favorite stuffed animal
- ☐ Two changes of clothes
- ☐ A small bag of snacks they like
- ☐ Their water cup
- ☐ A small surprise (their choice)
- ☐ A photo of you both, in their bag

THE FIRST MEETING WITH THE NEW BABY

Where: _____

When: _____

Who's there: _____

Photos: ☐ yes ☐ no ☐ only one

The "gift from the baby" decision:

☐ yes

☐ no

If yes, what: _____

A NOTE ON THE FIRST MEETING

- ☐ The older one walks into the room first.
The new baby is in the bassinet, NOT in the birthing parent's arms.
- ☐ The birthing parent's arms are free, so the older one can be hugged first.
- ☐ The "gift from the baby" is given quietly after the first hug, not at the door.

THE FIRST 24 HOURS PLAN

Visitors at the hospital: ☐ no ☐ family only

The older one stays: ☐ at home, brief visit

☐ at the hospital

The “arms free at first meeting” detail matters more than it sounds. The visual of the new baby being held by the parent who has been gone for a day, while the older one walks in, can be a heavy memory.

The first week home script library

For when you are now four people (or more) and the older one is processing.

When the older one is being clingy

"You can be close to me. I'm right here.
I have not gone anywhere."

"My lap is for you and for the baby. Right
now there is room for both."

"I'm holding the baby. I am also still
holding you. Both can be true."

When the older one is being rough with the baby

"Soft hands. Show me your soft hands."

"You can show the baby with your softest
fingers. Touch their foot, very gentle."

"I'm going to move the baby. You are not in
trouble. I want everyone safe."

"I see that you are angry. I'm not going
to be mad at you. I'm going to keep the
baby safe."

When the older one is regressing

"You want to be small for a minute. I get it.
I can hold you small."

"You can talk like a baby. I love your real
voice, and I love this voice too."

"Of course you want to be carried. Today is
a big day."

When the older one says "I don't like the baby"

"Some days the baby is a lot. I get it. I
don't have to like everything about the
baby today either."

"You don't have to love them yet. We have
a lot of time. Right now we just have
today."

"Thank you for telling me. You can tell
me anything."

When the older one is being ignored at the front door

(To a visitor, intercepting at the door:)

"Hi! Before you meet the baby, ____
(older child's name) is here. Hi, ____!
Look who's here to see you!"

(You set the example. The visitor follows.)

What to do during feeds

A list of twenty things the older one can do, alone, for the twenty to forty minutes of a feed. Set them up once, in week 35 of pregnancy. Keep in a basket near the nursing chair.

1. A puzzle that takes about 20 minutes
2. A bag of magnetic tiles
3. A stack of stickers + plain paper
4. A coloring book with a few favorite pages marked
5. A small basket of board books they love
6. A "feed time" activity, used only during feeds (this is the trick)
7. Watercolor paints (set up on a towel)
8. Play-doh in a small mat
9. A magnetic drawing board (the kind that erases when you slide)
10. A pack of pipe cleaners and beads
11. A small box of "treasure" rocks and shells
12. A bin of dried beans + scoops + cups
13. A flashlight + a book (in a tent / under a blanket)
14. Their own "baby" (doll) and a soft cloth
15. An audiobook in the next room (one chapter is roughly one feed)
16. A small wooden train track
17. Lacing cards
18. Cooking magazines to flip through
19. A pretend grocery store setup
20. Three of these in rotation, kept rare

THINGS TO AVOID

- A new toy every feed (becomes the only way to do feeds)
- Screens, if you can avoid (becomes a dependency that's hard to walk back)
- "Help me with the baby" (sometimes good, not for every feed. It makes the baby a chore)

The trick is the "only during feeds" activity. Whatever it is, it lives in the basket and only comes out when you are nursing or bottle-feeding. The novelty stays fresh because the activity is rare.

Grandparent scripts (so the older one is not eclipsed)

A page to send to anyone who is going to walk in your front door in the first six weeks.

Dear _____,

Thank you for wanting to meet the new baby.

A small ask:

When you arrive, please:

1. Greet _____ (the older sibling)
FIRST, by name. Hug them. Say their
name out loud. Make a big deal of them.
2. Then ask if you can meet the baby. Not
assume. Ask.
3. Bring a small gift for _____ (the
older one), in addition to anything for
the baby. Even a small one. Even a snack.
4. When you hold the baby, ask _____
(the older one) to come sit with you. Make
it a together-thing.
5. Do not say "you must love the baby!" or
"isn't the baby cute?" without involving
the older one in the question.

The baby is fine. The baby is being adored
already, by us, around the clock. The older
one is the one whose universe just shifted.
Help us hold them in the change.

Thank you.

_____ + _____

The night-shift plan

A short page about who handles night wakings of the older one in the first six weeks.

General principle

The birthing parent is recovering from a major bodily event AND establishing a feeding rhythm with the new baby. Older-child night wakings (bad dreams, "I need water," "where are you?") should, where possible, be handled by the other parent.

What to write down

NIGHT WAKING OF THE OLDER ONE, WEEKS 1-6

Default response: _____
(e.g., "Other parent goes")

If the other parent is also asleep / unavailable:

The "where is mom" script (if asked):

(e.g., "Mommy is sleeping. She just fed the baby. She'll see you in the morning.")

The reassurance script:

The reassurance script, expanded

"I'm here. You're safe. The baby is fine.
Mommy is fine. I'm going to lie next to you
for a few minutes. You can close your eyes."

The child does not need a long explanation. They need a body in the room. Five minutes usually does it. Sometimes two.

A one-on-one time page

The single most-protective ritual for an older sibling in the postpartum window is regular, predictable, one-on-one time with each parent.

What “one-on-one” means

- Just the two of you. No baby in the carrier. No baby in the next room with the door open.
- A small block. Twenty to thirty minutes is enough.
- Same time each day, if you can. The predictability is half the value.
- The child knows it is coming. “After lunch, we have our walk.”

Easy candidates

- ☐ Morning, after breakfast: 20 minutes of book reading in their room
- ☐ Late morning: a walk to the corner store (the partner stays with the baby)
- ☐ Bath time: just the older one in the bath, not the baby (use a different bath time for the baby)
- ☐ Bedtime: 15 minutes of book + lights low, parent-of-the-day rotates
- ☐ Saturday morning: a small outing, just the two of you

A note for the birthing parent

If the bath / book / bedtime can be the birthing parent (when physical recovery allows), it is high-value. The older one will have been feeling a distance from you for weeks. The one-on-one time repairs it.

If physical recovery does not allow, that's fine. The other parent does the one-on-one. The birthing parent does theirs once they can.

The page for just the older one

Print this. Read it together. Or read it and don't show it. Or wait until they're older.

Dear _____,

You are our first.

You were our first kid. You were the one we
were learning on. You were the one who taught
us almost everything we know about being parents.

We are about to have another baby. The baby
will be small and noisy and will need a lot of
our attention. This will not always feel fair.
It will not always BE fair.

But you will always be our first.

The way you have made our family is not a thing
the new baby can change. It is a thing you did,
and it cannot be undone.

We are so glad you are here.

With love,

_____ + _____

You can read it to them on the day you bring the baby home. You can keep it tucked into your wallet for the day they ask. You can read it to yourself, in the kitchen, at 4am, and remember why you are doing all of this.

A short note about the kids three years apart, eighteen months apart, five years apart

The pack works across the spacing range. The script density just shifts:

Eighteen months apart

Lean heavily on the “during-feeds basket” and the “soft hands” scripts. The older one cannot understand the concept of “baby” intellectually. They will mostly just experience the redistribution of your time. Plan for more clinginess, less verbal grief.

Three years apart

The sweet spot for verbal grief. The kid will tell you, in real words, that they are sad / angry / scared. Use the scripts. Take their words seriously.

Five years apart

The older child is usually capable of real helpfulness AND real complicated feelings. Don't lean too hard on “you're such a big helper” (it sounds like an assignment). Lean on one-on-one time and on validating that some days the baby is a lot, even for the adult.

The reflection page

A page at the back, for filling in much later.

We became a family of more on ____.

The first day __ (older sibling) and __ (new sibling) seemed to actually like each other was around ____.

The hardest week of the transition was ____.

The thing I learned about ____ (older sibling) that I did not know before was:

The thing I would do again, exactly the same:

The thing I would do differently:

Numbers to keep

PEDIATRICIAN (for both kids)

Name: _____ Number: _____

PEDIATRIC THERAPIST (if applicable)

Name: _____ Number: _____

EMERGENCY BACKUP CAREGIVER FOR THE OLDER ONE

Name: _____ Number: _____

US PARENT STRESS LINE

1-800-422-4453 (Childhelp, 24/7, confidential)

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (24/7, free, confidential)



From Soothemade Notes, a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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